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Tuesday, 4 October 2005

The Geometer as Conjuror

The Status of Force in Newton-Cartan Theory

Alexander Afriat, U. of Urbino, Italy

12:05 pm, 817R Cathedral of Learning

Abstract: I consider epistemological implications of Cartan's generally covariant theory of Newtonian gravity, which allows one to choose between a flat geometry plus force, and a curved geometry into which force has been 'absorbed'. Can the geometer conjure up force at the stroke of a pen? Is force an empty mathematical fiction?